

Scoring Translation in the NBA Playoffs (Since 2000)

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Project Overview

It is a basketball cliché that the playoffs are a different game. But it holds up. Defenses tighten, weak points get hunted, and stars see entire game plans built to make life harder.

A player scoring 27 a night in January is not facing the same game as someone trying to get to 27 in May. The volume might look the same. The difficulty does not.

That is where playoff discourse often misses. Players get labeled as risers or droppers off one stretch, even when the sample is too small to mean much. This looks at the bigger picture: not just who scores, but whose scoring actually translates when defenses are built to take it away.

Definitions

This analysis focuses on scoring translation: how a player's playoff scoring compares to their regular-season averages.

Pretext

Regular-season production is measured only from seasons in which the player reached the playoffs.

This keeps the comparison focused on a player's playoff-era version of himself, rather than being dragged down by early-career or non-playoff seasons.

Scoring Change

PPG Difference (Diff) = Playoff PPG – Regular Season PPG

Positive values = increase in scoring. Negative values = decline.

Efficiency

rTS Change measures how a player's scoring efficiency shifts relative to league average from the regular season to the playoffs.

It is calculated as playoff rTS minus regular-season rTS.

A negative value means the player became less efficient relative to the league, even if overall league efficiency also declined. That change should always be read alongside playoff rTS itself.

Classification

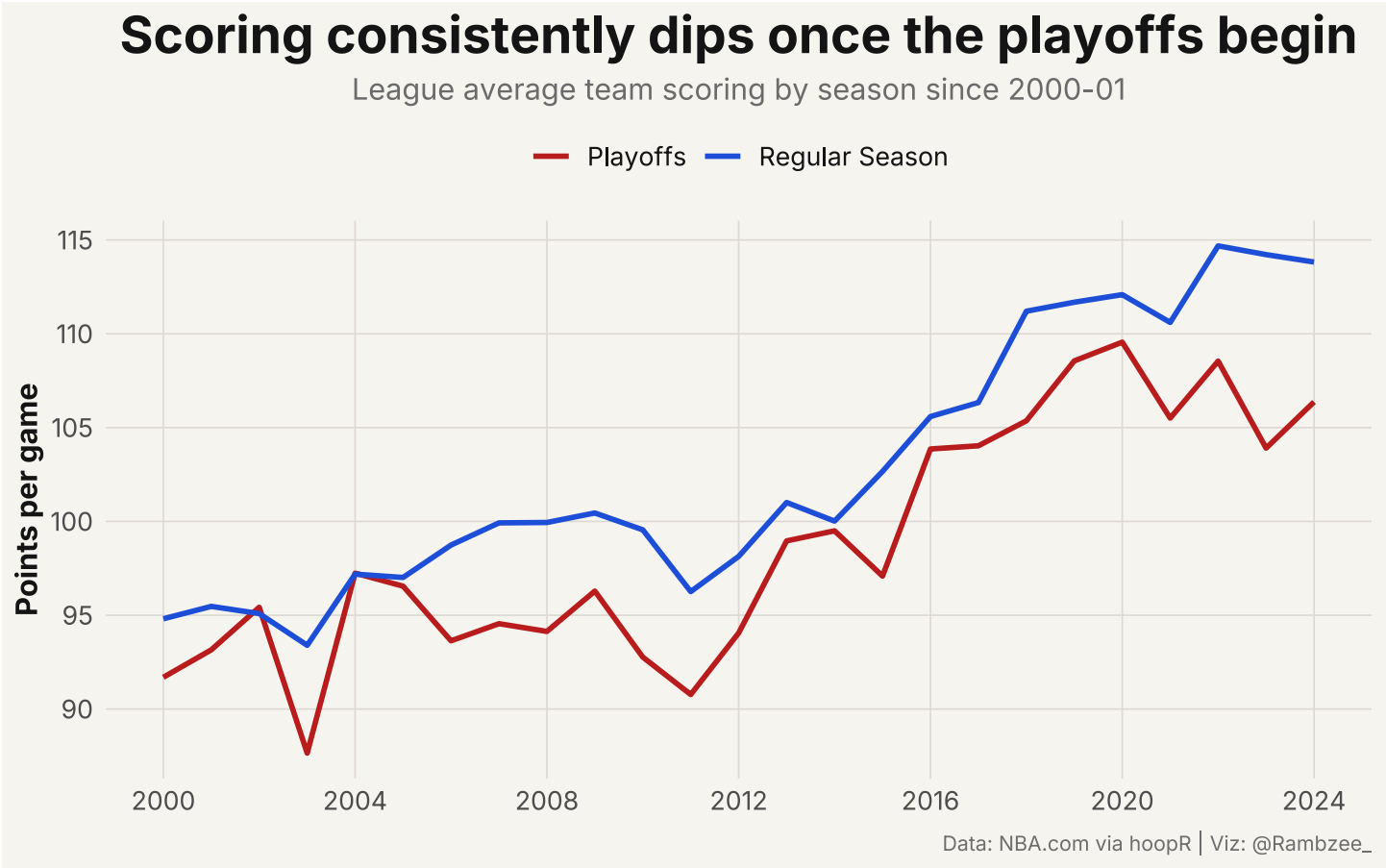
Players are grouped into three categories:

- Risers: scoring increases in the playoffs
- Maintainers: scoring remains within ± 1 PPG
- Droppers: scoring decreases

For droppers, results are filtered to remove most obvious role-loss cases. This helps isolate players whose scoring declined despite similar offensive responsibility, making the drop more meaningful.

Riser seasons are interpreted with more context. Some increases come from higher scoring load, while others reflect genuine shotmaking and efficiency gains.

Playoff Scoring (Regular Season vs Playoffs - Since 2000)



While scoring has climbed across the league since 2000, one trend has stayed the same: offense gets harder in the playoffs.

That changes how production should be read. Holding your scoring is already a win. Pushing beyond it is rare. Falling off is common.

Once the game tightens, some players survive it, a few rise above it, and others get dragged down by the kind of attention and physicality only playoff basketball brings.

Best Playoff Performers of All-Time and of the Modern Era

Before looking at how scoring changes, it helps to establish who has actually produced the most in playoff settings.

All-Time Leaders

These are the most productive playoff performers in NBA history, filtered for players with at least 50 postseason games.

Minimum 50 playoff games / star = active player / Data: Basketball-Reference

Scoring

Rank	Player	GP	PPG
1	Michael Jordan	179	33.45
2	Luka Dončić*	55	30.85
3	Allen Iverson	71	29.73
4	Kevin Durant*	170	29.32
5	Jerry West	153	29.13
6	Donovan Mitchell*	65	28.38
7	LeBron James*	293	28.35
8	Nikola Jokić*	94	27.39
9	Elgin Baylor	134	27.04
10	Giannis Antetokounmpo*	84	27.02
11	George Gervin	59	26.98
12	Stephen Curry*	155	26.75
13	Anthony Davis*	60	26.1

Rebounding

Rank	Player	GP	RPG
1	Bill Russell	165	24.87
2	Wilt Chamberlain	160	24.46
3	Wes Unseld	119	14.93
4	Bob Pettit	88	14.82
5	Dave Cowens	89	14.44
6	George Mikan	60	13.85
7	Moses Malone	94	13.78
8	Nate Thurmond	81	13.59
9	Elvin Hayes	96	12.96
10	Elgin Baylor	134	12.87
11	Charles Barkley	123	12.86
12	Nikola Jokić*	94	12.36
13	Dolph Schayes	97	12.22

Playmaking

Rank	Player	GP	APG
1	Magic Johnson	190	12.35
2	John Stockton	182	10.1
3	Oscar Robertson	86	8.94
4	Kevin Johnson	105	8.9
5	Isiah Thomas	111	8.89
6	Steve Nash	120	8.84
7	Bob Cousy	109	8.6
8	Rajon Rondo	134	8.48
9	Chris Paul	149	8.28
10	Norm Nixon	58	8.02
11	Jason Kidd	158	7.99
12	Luka Dončić*	55	7.76
13	Nikola Jokić*	94	7.61

Across eras, the same types of players rise to the top. Scorers who cannot be pushed off their spots. Bigs who control the glass. Primary creators who can still organize offense when everything slows down.

The other thing that stands out is volume. Players like Jordan, LeBron, Magic, and Russell built these numbers over massive playoff samples, essentially adding multiple extra seasons at the highest level.

Modern Leaders

For all the similarities, there are still real differences across eras. The positions that dominate change. The schemes change. The style of offense changes. And so do some of the names that end up at the top of these leaderboards.

To make the comparison cleaner, it helps to narrow the lens to the modern game. Here are the players who stand out as the playoff leaders of this era.

Top playoff scorers

Player	PO G	Playoff PPG
Luka Dončić	55	30.9
Allen Iverson	53	30.6
Kevin Durant	170	29.3
Kobe Bryant	170	28.5
LeBron James	292	28.4
Donovan Mitchell	63	28.3
Nikola Jokić	94	27.4
Giannis Antetokounmpo	84	27.0
Stephen Curry	155	26.8
Anthony Davis	60	26.1

Top playoff rebounders

Player	PO G	Playoff RPG
Nikola Jokić	94	12.3
Giannis Antetokounmpo	84	12.2
Dwight Howard	125	11.8
Anthony Davis	60	11.7
Tim Duncan	225	11.5
Ben Wallace	130	11.2
Shaquille O'Neal	127	11.2
Carlos Boozer	83	11.1
Joel Embiid	59	10.9
Kevin Garnett	127	10.8

Top playoff playmakers

Player	PO G	Playoff APG
Steve Nash	112	9.4
Rajon Rondo	134	8.5
Chris Paul	149	8.3
Jason Kidd	140	7.9
Luka Dončić	55	7.8
Nikola Jokić	94	7.6
LeBron James	292	7.2
Russell Westbrook	135	7.1
Deron Williams	90	7.0
James Harden	173	6.5

The modern leaderboards show who has stood out as the defining playoff producers of the past 25 years.

The names that show up more than once are the biggest story. Luka. Jokić. LeBron. Giannis. Anthony Davis. These are not one-skill playoff stars. They affect the game in too many ways to be cleanly removed from it, most often by pairing elite physical tools with the feel to exploit whatever matchup is in front of them.

That same theme carries over when the lens shifts from per-game production to the biggest single playoff runs.

Biggest Single-Run Playoff Totals (Since 2000)

These totals capture the biggest modern playoff performances over a single run.

Points

Player	Season	Team	PO G	Points
LeBron James	2017-18	CLE	22	748.0
Kawhi Leonard	2018-19	TOR	24	732.0
Allen Iverson	2000-01	PHI	22	723.8
LeBron James	2011-12	MIA	23	696.9
Kobe Bryant	2008-09	LAL	23	694.6

Rebounds

Player	Season	Team	PO G	Rebounds
Tim Duncan	2002-03	SAS	24	369.6
Dwight Howard	2008-09	ORL	23	351.9
Ben Wallace	2003-04	DET	23	328.9
Dikembe Mutombo	2000-01	PHI	23	315.1
Shaquille O'Neal	2003-04	LAL	22	290.4

Assists

Player	Season	Team	PO G	Assists
Rajon Rondo	2011-12	BOS	19	226.1
Rajon Rondo	2009-10	BOS	24	223.2
Steve Nash	2005-06	PHX	20	204.0
Jrue Holiday	2020-21	MIL	23	200.1
Russell Westbrook	2015-16	OKC	18	198.0

Steals

Player	Season	Team	PO G	Steals
Allen Iverson	2000-01	PHI	22	52
Dwyane Wade	2005-06	MIA	23	51
LeBron James	2015-16	CLE	21	49
Rajon Rondo	2009-10	BOS	24	46
Russell Westbrook	2015-16	OKC	18	46

Blocks

Player	Season	Team	PO G	Blocks
Tim Duncan	2002-03	SAS	24	79
Dikembe Mutombo	2000-01	PHI	23	72
Tim Duncan	2006-07	SAS	20	62
Shaquille O'Neal	2003-04	LAL	22	61
Dwight Howard	2008-09	ORL	23	60

Single-run totals show something per-game averages cannot. They capture what it looks like when a player has to sustain elite production over an entire playoff run.

Some of these are burned into playoff history: LeBron dragging Cleveland through the 2018 East, Kawhi carrying Toronto in 2019, Iverson's absurd 2001 shot diet, Kobe controlling a title run in 2009.

They also show how different dominance can look. Duncan owning the glass and the rim. Dwight overwhelming the paint. Rondo driving deep runs as Boston's engine.

More than anything, these totals show which players could carry massive responsibility for two months and still hold up.

Modern Playoff Performers Translation

Beyond averages and single runs, most playoff conversations come down to who rose and who fell. But that only means so much without the right baseline.

Here, regular-season production only comes from seasons where a player actually reached the playoffs, so the comparison stays tied to his real playoff window. This is not a career-value assessment. It is a look at whose scoring still translated once the game got tougher.

Largest career playoff scoring lifts

Player	RS G	PO G	RS PPG*	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Jimmy Butler III	742	130	17.9	21.1	3.2	18.1	-1.9	1.1
Nikola Jokić	517	94	24.8	27.4	2.7	10.7	-2.7	4.5
Antonio Daniels	608	61	7.9	10.4	2.5	31.2	2.2	4.3
Dirk Nowitzki	1158	145	23.1	25.3	2.2	9.4	-0.4	4.6
Chris Paul	1027	149	18.1	20.0	1.9	10.8	-0.4	3.4
Tim Duncan	1186	225	18.5	20.4	1.9	10.2	-0.2	1.4
Steve Nash	754	112	16.6	18.3	1.6	9.8	-2.9	5.3
Jason Terry	972	124	12.5	14.1	1.6	12.5	-1.4	1.4
Chauncey Billups	866	146	15.9	17.3	1.4	8.5	-1.7	3.9
Luka Dončić	312	55	29.5	30.9	1.3	4.6	-1.3	0.5
Kawhi Leonard	724	146	20.1	21.5	1.3	6.5	2.4	7.1
Kevin Durant	880	170	28.1	29.3	1.2	4.3	-2.5	5.5

This is probably the messiest group of the three, because not every rise means the same thing.

Jimmy is the obvious example. The scoring jump is real, but so is the burden. Once the playoffs start, everything swings further in his direction and the production still climbs.

Jokić is a different kind of riser. The jump is smaller, but it comes while he is still controlling the whole offense and staying elite efficiency-wise. Kawhi fits that mold too. The increase is not huge, but it is on much better efficiency, and that matters more.

Then there are players like Nash, Durant, and Chris Paul. The increases are smaller, but they come while carrying offensive responsibility that usually pulls efficiency down.

That is the line this table is trying to draw. More points does not always mean better playoff translation. Sometimes it just means more shots. The players who really stand out are the ones whose games still scale when the pressure rises.

Best career maintainers

Player	RS G	PO G	RS PPG*	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Kobe Bryant	829	170	28.3	28.5	0.3	0.9	-0.3	2.0
Anthony Davis	373	60	25.5	26.1	0.6	2.5	1.3	5.6
Jayson Tatum	585	121	23.6	24.3	0.7	3.0	-1.1	0.1
Dwyane Wade	869	177	22.4	22.3	-0.1	-0.5	-0.4	1.2
Paul George	774	114	20.5	21.2	0.7	3.3	-1.4	0.4
Jaylen Brown	545	135	18.3	19.3	1.0	5.4	1.1	0.8
Amar'e Stoudemire	670	78	19.3	18.7	-0.6	-3.0	-1.8	4.6
Paul Pierce	1014	170	18.6	18.7	0.2	0.8	-1.7	1.9
Blake Griffin	607	68	18.3	18.2	-0.1	-0.8	-0.7	0.6
Kevin Garnett	719	127	18.2	18.2	0.0	0.1	-1.0	0.7
Ray Allen	670	163	16.7	15.8	-0.9	-5.6	-1.2	5.0
Deron Williams	645	90	16.2	15.7	-0.6	-3.4	-0.4	1.1

This is arguably the most important group. Maintaining may sound boring, but it is one of the hardest things to do in playoff basketball.

Most players drop in the playoffs. Holding your level is not neutral, it is one of the clearest signs your scoring holds up.

Kobe. Wade. AD. Tatum. Players who stayed near their regular-season production even as possessions got harder and defenses loaded up.

Biggest career droppers

Player	RS G	PO G	RS PPG*	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Tyler Herro	361	50	19.3	14.6	-4.8	-24.6	-4.1	-4.8
Sam Cassell	368	73	17.6	13.6	-4.0	-22.8	-4.3	-2.1
Michael Porter Jr.	336	75	16.4	13.0	-3.4	-20.6	-4.6	0.0
Lou Williams	727	89	14.6	11.4	-3.2	-22.1	-3.6	-4.1
Mikal Bridges	319	57	16.5	13.9	-2.6	-15.5	-4.3	-0.2
Jermaine O'Neal	609	77	16.4	14.3	-2.2	-13.2	-2.7	-2.9
Kyle Lowry	742	136	15.5	13.5	-2.0	-12.8	-3.7	-1.6
DeMar DeRozan	524	63	23.8	21.8	-1.9	-8.1	-4.2	-4.5
Bojan Bogdanovic	518	51	15.0	13.1	-1.9	-12.7	-3.7	-0.5
Kevin Love	388	88	14.5	12.7	-1.9	-12.8	-2.4	-0.8
Rashard Lewis	489	88	14.5	12.7	-1.8	-12.5	-3.1	-0.1
Mike Bibby	705	105	14.4	12.6	-1.7	-12.1	-2.5	-2.1

This group tells the other side of the story, players whose production consistently fell when expectations and responsibilities rose.

A lot of these names line up with playoff frustrations people already remember. DeRozan in those Cleveland series. Lou Williams in bench-heavy scoring roles that got harder to sustain. Herro in a setting where the weaknesses become easier to target.

That points to the bigger question underneath all of this: what kinds of scoring actually hold up in the playoffs? Some styles survive playoff attention. Others persist as weak points and crack once a defense has a full series to exploit them.

Modern Single-Run Performers Translation

Career numbers smooth everything out. Single runs don't.

They capture what happens when everything clicks, or when everything breaks, over the course of one playoff run.

Biggest playoff risers by season

Player	Season	Team	RS G	PO G	RS PPG	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Steve Nash	2004-05	PHX	75	15	15.5	23.9	8.4	54.2	-0.4	7.2
Jamal Murray	2019-20	DEN	59	19	18.5	26.5	8.0	43.2	5.7	5.1
Tim Duncan	2005-06	SAS	80	13	18.6	25.8	7.2	38.7	9.0	7.8
Reggie Jackson	2020-21	LAC	67	19	10.7	17.8	7.1	66.4	4.5	5.3
Nick Van Exel	2002-03	DAL	73	20	12.5	19.5	7.0	56.0	3.4	2.6
LeBron James	2008-09	CLE	81	14	28.4	35.3	6.9	24.3	2.7	7.4
Mike Bibby	2001-02	SAC	80	16	13.7	20.3	6.6	48.2	4.2	3.5
LeBron James	2017-18	CLE	82	22	27.5	34.0	6.5	23.6	-0.1	6.4
Jameer Nelson	2009-10	ORL	65	14	12.6	19.0	6.4	50.8	7.3	6.8
Paul Millsap	2009-10	UTA	82	10	11.6	18.0	6.4	55.2	3.6	6.7

These are runs where players truly rose to the occasion and played out of their minds. Steve Nash's ahead-of-his-time scoring explosion in 2005. Duncan trying to drag the Spurs to a title in 2006. Jamal Murray announcing himself with one of the biggest playoff jumps of the modern era. LeBron overwhelming entire runs in 2009 and 2018.

A lot of these are star burdens pushed to the edge. In some cases, the size of the scoring jump is almost a sign that too much was being asked of one player.

Then there are different kinds of rises. Role players becoming lifesavers for a stretch. Reggie Jackson. Mike Bibby. Jameer Nelson. Nick Van Exel. Not full offensive engines, but players who became critical once the postseason demanded more.

That is what makes riser discourse so tricky. Not every rise means the same thing. Some players caught fire for one run. Others reached a level their teams could actually lean on deep into the playoffs. But in every case, this is what a real postseason jump looks like when it happens all at once.

Most important: the maintainers

Player	Season	Team	RS G	PO G	RS PPG	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Kobe Bryant	2000-01	LAL	68	16	28.5	29.4	0.9	3.2	0.9	4.3
LeBron James	2009-10	CLE	76	11	29.7	29.1	-0.6	-2.0	0.2	6.3
Kevin Durant	2010-11	OKC	78	17	27.7	28.6	0.9	3.2	0.4	5.2
Kevin Durant	2011-12	OKC	66	20	28.0	28.5	0.5	1.8	3.0	11.1
Stephen Curry	2018-19	GSW	69	22	27.3	28.2	0.9	3.3	-1.3	6.9
Joel Embiid	2020-21	PHI	51	11	28.5	28.1	-0.4	-1.4	-0.6	6.0
LeBron James	2013-14	MIA	77	20	27.1	27.4	0.3	1.1	1.4	12.0
Vince Carter	2000-01	TOR	75	12	27.6	27.3	-0.3	-1.1	-2.0	1.3
James Harden	2014-15	HOU	81	17	27.4	27.2	-0.2	-0.7	2.2	9.4
Dirk Nowitzki	2005-06	DAL	81	23	26.6	27.0	0.4	1.5	-0.3	5.0

Looking at the single-run maintainers, this is where a lot of the all-time great postseason runs reside. Not necessarily players dragging an offense by themselves, but stars taking on bigger burdens and still scaling to them.

Kobe in 2001. LeBron in multiple years. Durant. Curry. Dirk. These runs now read as part of their case for greatness. The scoring load was already huge, the playoff attention was already there, and they still held their level through deep runs.

That is what makes these performances so impressive. There is no surprise factor here. No one was catching defenses off guard. These were stars facing full playoff game plans and still getting to their numbers anyway.

That is also where a lot of playoff discourse gets warped. A player does not need some giant scoring spike to have had an incredible postseason. Sometimes the most impressive thing is just holding your level while everything around you gets harder.

Biggest playoff droppers by season

Player	Season	Team	RS G	PO G	RS PPG	PO PPG	Diff	% Change	rTS Change	PO rTS
Joel Embiid	2022-23	PHI	66	9	33.1	23.7	-9.4	-28.4	-7.9	-0.4
Russell Westbrook	2019-20	HOU	57	8	27.2	17.9	-9.3	-34.2	-7.9	-10.9
Michael Porter Jr.	2024-25	DEN	77	14	18.2	9.1	-9.1	-50.0	-10.6	-6.3
Julius Randle	2022-23	NYK	77	10	25.1	16.6	-8.5	-33.9	-8.0	-8.1
Jermaine O'Neal	2004-05	IND	44	13	24.3	16.0	-8.3	-34.2	-9.6	-10.4
Klay Thompson	2016-17	GSW	78	17	22.3	15.0	-7.3	-32.7	-9.4	-5.4
Joel Embiid	2018-19	PHI	64	11	27.5	20.2	-7.3	-26.5	-2.7	0.7
Nick Van Exel	2001-02	DAL	72	8	18.4	11.1	-7.3	-39.7	-7.2	-9.5
Clint Capela	2018-19	HOU	67	11	16.6	9.7	-6.9	-41.6	-10.4	-0.7
Gary Payton	2003-04	LAL	82	22	14.6	7.8	-6.8	-46.6	-8.1	-7.0

On the flip side, this is where some of the most damaging runs live. The kinds of playoff performances that follow players around for years, and for some unlucky names here, show up more than once.

Drops happen for a lot of reasons. Injuries. Bad shooting luck. Tough matchups. Defensive game plans finally catching up. But the worst runs usually expose something deeper. A scoring style that was always unstable. A shot diet that gets harder to survive on. Free-throw reliance that dries up. Regular-season advantages that disappear once every possession is being played with real force and attention.

That is what makes these runs different. They are not just bad stretches. They are often the point where a player's scoring style stops translating altogether.

And that is why they stick. Not just because the numbers cratered, but because the playoffs made the weakness impossible to ignore.

Conclusion

The playoffs do not create a player out of nowhere. More often, they reveal what was already there.

They show the value of scalable scoring, dependable ballhandling, and players who can settle a game when everything gets tighter. They can change the way a career is talked about, separating empty production from the kinds of offensive games that actually hold up in May and June.

That is why playoff translation matters. Not because every drop is an indictment or every rise is proof of greatness, but because the postseason is where scoring styles get tested the hardest and judged the clearest.